



Early buzz missing: In the USA, signage is plentiful, and so are the media, primarily Brazilian. Missing, though, are the fans who followed their teams everywhere in Russia and Qatar. AFP

sports in the American pantheon, long dominated by the NFL, NBA, MLB and NHL.

Americans are strangely oblivious to the world around them. Their local league champions, who are similar to our IPL champions, are called world champions. They have merely won a league played in the United States, with a smattering of representatives from their North American neighbour, Canada. Yet they unabashedly call themselves champions of the world, a boastfulness that even our cricket mandarins, despite controlling much of world cricket, would never dare claim.

By now, somewhere over the Atlantic, you begin to regret your choices. Putting a body of 40 summers, and a few more to

come, through this ordeal seems a heavy price to pay. Football, however, has a remarkable ability to convince otherwise sensible people to do deeply inconvenient things.

Landing at Newark Liberty International Airport offers the first signs that a World Cup is arriving. Yet the mood is nothing like the festive atmosphere encountered at earlier editions of the tournament.

A long queue of Brazilian fans and journalists arriving in New York ahead of their side's first game against Morocco suggests that a tournament is approaching. The airport signage, immigration officials and luggage counters, however, seem oblivious to the arrival of the world's greatest sporting spectacle.

The drive to the hotel, barely

five miles from MetLife Stadium, which will host the World Cup final on July 19, does little to ease the apprehension. Does the World Cup really matter to the United States? Sundry road signs indicating match-day restrictions are the only telltale signs of a major sporting event. MetLife, a giant bowl rising above the New Jersey landscape, looks imposing enough to stage a match of that magnitude.

Signage is plentiful and the media are here too, primarily Brazilian. Missing are the fans who followed their teams everywhere in Russia and Qatar. Come Saturday, when the game unfolds, perhaps we will be proved wrong and New York will show us that football, and its greatest showpiece, matter to the city.